

INTRODUCTION

IF YOU'RE LIKE a lot of people in their twenties and thirties, you're worried about money. And who can blame you? The nation's finances haven't been this bad since the Great Depression, and the only saving grace is that you probably didn't have all that much money to invest in the stock market to begin with.

So how do you get on the right track when the whole financial world is dealing with the wreckage of the Great Recession? It's a challenge, for sure. But even in these tough times and even without a big income, you *can* take control of your financial life. Now more than ever, you need a playbook—a guide that teaches you the skills and strategies of managing money. *This is that playbook.*

When I wrote the first version of *Get a Financial Life* more than ten years ago, I was told that people in their twenties and thirties don't think about their finances and the book would never sell. To everyone's surprise—including mine—it became a *New York Times* bestseller and is now in its fourteenth printing. Every week I receive emails (in the '90s, I actually got letters) from readers, many of whom are now in their forties, who say that this book changed their lives. The reason, I think, is that the book makes clear that there are just a few key steps you need to get out of debt, start saving, and plan for the future. Once you nail these easy concepts, you'll be on your way—in good times or bad.